

Dear Study Members,

Welcome to our 2025 Spring Newsletter!

Our most important activity currently is distributing our new questionnaire. Invitations are being sent to participants with an email address or mobile number on file (please see link/QR code to update your information if it has changed). We started in February and everyone with emails or mobile numbers should receive an invitation by the summer. To ensure that questionnaires are completed, we will also be sending reminders via email and text messages – you can also access the questionnaire by scanning the QR code below. The success of the Breast Cancer Now Generations Study relies on high-quality data provided through your

responses to the questionnaires. We are incredibly grateful for your participation in helping us maintain an excellent response rate.

In our research update, below, we provide information on the number of participants in the study who reported to us that they have been diagnosed with breast cancer or other types of cancer. We also explain how we plan to use NHS medical records to collect important health information, including cancer diagnoses, to support our research effort.

We held our second participant panel meeting in November last year and received excellent feedback about our communications including newsletters and have made changes as a result. Two of our panel members tell us about their experience in this newsletter.

To help us keep in touch, please let us know if you change your email address or mobile phone number by completing the change of details form online at <https://bgs.icr.ac.uk/update/> or by scanning the QR code above.



We value your continued participation in The Breast Cancer Now Generations Study and look forward to the new research discoveries the study brings. As always, we welcome your feedback on our research plans and our newsletters.

With best wishes,

Professor Amy Berrington
Professor Montserrat García-Closas

Have you completed the latest study questionnaire this year?

If not, this is available for completion here: <https://generations.questionnaire.icr.ac.uk/q5> or by scanning the QR code.



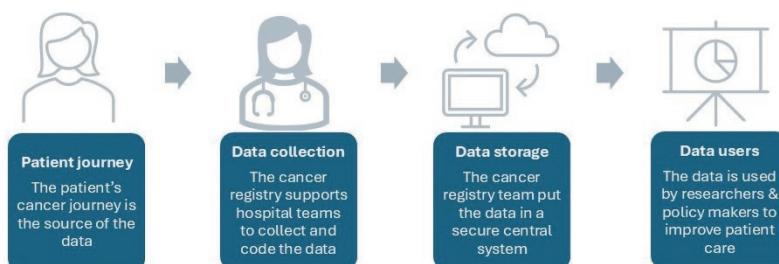
Thank you, we are most grateful for your time and valued contribution to the study research

RESEARCH UPDATE

Collecting information on who has been diagnosed with cancer

Since the study started in 2004, approximately 4,000 of the 113,000 study participants have reported to us that they have been diagnosed with breast cancer, and 5,000 have been diagnosed with other types of cancer. Until now, we have relied on your responses through questionnaires or notifications to learn about these cancer diagnoses. This year, we are introducing a new method to identify cancer diagnoses using the NHS cancer registration system.

This diagram demonstrates how data on cancer diagnoses are collected by the NHS to support research like The Breast Cancer Now Generations Study, to plan NHS services and help improve outcomes for patients. The main advantage of using this system for our study is that we can get more detailed and accurate information about the type of cancer by gathering information directly from the NHS for all participants who gave consent to access their medical records when they joined the study. Additionally, this allows us to learn about other health conditions,



Cancer Registration - the Data Journey

and then use this study data to explore the causes of other common diseases affecting women in the UK.

NHS England has given us permission to use the cancer registration system and other types of NHS records for our study to collect information about cancer and other serious medical conditions such as cardiovascular disease. We plan to apply to the NHS in Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland for approval to extend this method to all participants. NHS England has asked that we explain this process to you using this statement below from the official approval.

"We plan to make changes to the way that we collect information about the health of participants in the Breast Cancer Now Generations Study. We want to make you aware that from now on we will be accessing centralised NHS records to collect information about your health. By 'centralised NHS records' we mean records held by NHS England, NHS Scotland, NHS Wales, and Health and Social Care in Northern Ireland. We would share with them identifying details such as name, date of birth, and NHS number, in order to link to their

...continued on p2

Continued from p1...

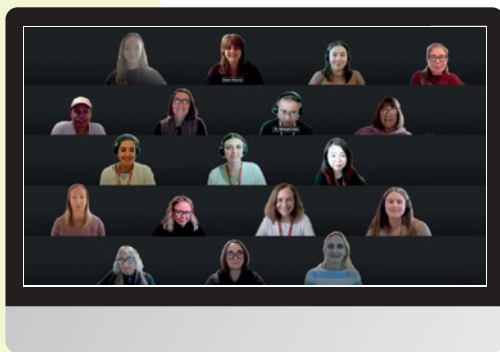
records. This is in addition to asking you to fill-in information about your health in the regular questionnaires. Previously, we only used the central NHS records for participants we had lost contact with. The reason we plan to make this

change is for the scientific benefits this would bring to the study in terms of data completeness and accuracy. Without the data from all the participants, the results could be incomplete, inaccurate and biased. We are not proposing

to introduce new procedures or methodology, or change the design of the study. If you do not want this to take place for you (accessing information from your NHS medical records) please email generationscohort@icr.ac.uk

Participant panel meeting

We held our second online participant panel meeting in November. Here's the screenshot from the meeting and below we hear from two participants (Arlene and Katie) about their experience of being members of the panel.



ARLENE



I chose to participate in the Generations Study after reading an article about how race and ethnicity affect how patients respond to drugs and how the diversity gap in clinical trials could be undermining outcomes for minorities. After understanding how clinical trials are used to make major decisions around future treatments and drug development pathways, I felt compelled to do my bit and become part of the solution, not part of the problem. By volunteering, I wanted to ensure future research, and any trials and cohorts better reflected the communities they serve.

I am single, driven and a management consultant, who enjoys playing sport, keeping up with friends and having fun. I'm a firm believer that life's too short and that kindness and caring are under-rated values.

Participating in the study has been very easy and interesting. The filling out of questionnaires is relatively quick and generally sent every few years. Of late, I have more time, so it's been interesting to read up on some of the research papers.

Lately, the ability to join a Participants Panel and engage directly with the researchers [and other participants] has been illuminating. It's so humbling to understand how the researchers are using my data to research the quirks of breast cancer.

I was happy to join the participants panel as I felt compelled to help make this study a success and shape the future of participants contributions in cohort studies. I'm convinced, over time, cohort studies can be developed to achieve so much more, and you can see The Breast Cancer Now Generations Study has been a template for Our Future Health and I'm sure the best is still yet to come.

It's been an insightful process, which has allowed me to deliver on a societal objective with very little effort. I'd like to think I've been able to be 'an influencer' whilst remaining private and discreet.

I initially joined up at my Mum's suggestion as she also was signing up. At the time I had just started university studying Pharmacy and I thought it was an exciting opportunity to take part in real life research. I also wanted to support research that has the potential to make women's lives better in the future, something I'm even more keenly aware of after having my own daughter seven years ago.

I've found the process to be super easy and straightforward. The questionnaires aren't too taxing, thankfully I have a relatively straightforward medical history so not too much to remember when adding in my details.

I continue to participate as it's straightforward and really doesn't take up too much of my time. I've worked in scientific research for the last 15 years and understand the vital need for continued participation from volunteers. Without us and our valuable input, whether it's filling out a questionnaire or giving consent for access to other data like medical records, the study would fall flat on its face.

I live in Belfast, Northern Ireland, with my husband Graeme, daughter Lily and stepson Jackson. Personally, I love life's simple pleasures. Quality time with my family and friends, getting outside to enjoy the beautiful Northern Irish coast and countryside. You'll often find me getting my hands dirty in the garden, baking in the kitchen or diving into a good book. I'll also never say no to a delicious meal paired with a great glass of wine.

Professionally, I'm currently a Principal Research Pharmacist working for a large pharmaceutical company. Prior to that I spent 10 years leading a



KATIE

manufacturing pharmacy department in a company that runs Clinical Trials. I also completed my PhD in Pharmaceutical Microbiology in Queen's University Belfast, after realising that a life counting tablets as a community pharmacist was not for me!

I'm always interested to see the study newsletters come out with new findings and see what the Generations team are up to, so when I was invited to join the participant panel, I was happy to do so. I was intrigued to find out more about the panel and what the team wanted us to do. I'm a curious (nosey) person by nature! So far, I've really enjoyed getting to meet some other participants and hear their own personal stories. The meetings have been well arranged by the Generations team, with lots of time for discussion and hearing everyone's viewpoints. It's also been great to get to meet more of the Generations team, especially some of the younger researchers just starting out in their careers and what they hope to achieve.

It's satisfying to be involved in giving feedback on what things work or don't work for participants, for example, testing out the questionnaires for functionality and advising on what we would like to see in the newsletter.